NAIROBI CONTEMPORARY ART INSTITUTE

Press Release
FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

PETERSON KAMWATHI: TABULA RASA
Solo Exhibition
25 April 2026 – 23 August 2026

The Nairobi Contemporary Art Institute (NCAI) presents *Tabula Rasa*, Peterson Kamwathi's first institutional solo exhibition in Kenya. The exhibition brings together drawings produced between 2022 and 2026 alongside new video, large-scale drawing, sculptures, and etchings — tracing how these media speak to and extend one another as Kamwathi's practice has expanded in recent years.

In the works gathered here, Kamwathi assembles figures, monuments, maps, and everyday objects into composite pictorial spaces that collapse multiple locations and histories into a single frame. The spaces his figures inhabit are deliberately unstable — terrains built from fragments of the real world, spliced and layered to draw out the connections between historical events and processes that continue to shape the present. Political monuments appear displaced and inverted. Quotidian objects are made monumental through scale and repetition. The ground beneath the figures and objects, the spaces they occupy, are as active and loaded as the figures themselves.

The exhibition takes its premise from the philosophical notion of the blank slate — and from the question of who benefits from declaring something empty. To call a place uninhabited, a signal absent, a culture void, is never innocent. It is a refusal of sight, and it has a history. That history is also the history of interference — of how our understanding of social and political realities is distorted through spectacularisation, and through the elevation of certain perspectives at the expense of others. Against this, Kamwathi proposes a mode of looking that is cumulative rather than linear, and oriented toward systems rather than isolated events.

About the Artist
Peterson Kamwathi's practice is grounded in an attentiveness to how power shapes collective life — how histories are made legible or obscured, how monuments accumulate meaning, and how the spaces people inhabit carry the residue of political decisions made elsewhere and long ago

Kamwathi's work has been exhibited in numerous venues around the world, and he was part of the Kenya national pavilion at the 57th Edition of the Venice Biennale in 2017. He has also participated in the Young Congo Biennale 2019 in Kinshasa, Congo DRC and the 8th edition of the Ake Arts and Book Festival, Lagos, in 2020. His work is included in collections of the Nairobi Contemporary Art Institute (NCAI), Safaricom, the British Museum, the Bates College of Art Museum, the East African Visual Arts Trust collection, and the World Bank Headquarters, among others. He lives in Limuru, Kenya

About NCAI
The Nairobi Contemporary Art Institute (NCAI) is a nonprofit visual arts space dedicated to the growth and preservation of contemporary art in East Africa. Through exhibitions, the development of an East African art archive, an extensive public program of talks, and a multidisciplinary educational program, NCAI serves as an inspiring cultural space and a resource for the thriving East African arts community. Established in 2020, NCAI builds on a rich legacy of art projects and institutions in the region, and seeks to tell the stories of the artists and projects that have come to shape the region's contemporary art scene.

Visitor Information

• The Nairobi Contemporary Art Institute is located at Rosslyn Riviera, 3rd floor, Suite 307, Limuru Road, Nairobi.

• NCAI is open to the public on Monday to Saturday, from 10 am to 6 pm, and Sunday from 12 noon to 5 pm. We remain closed on all public holidays.

• Admission: **FREE**

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